

MINUTES

The **Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Subcommittee Meeting** is held **May 16, 2023**, scheduled from 5 - 6p. The meeting is held via remote participation on Zoom and viewed through Medford Community Media on Comcast Channel 15 and Verizon Channel 45.

The Purpose of the Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Subcommittee Meeting is to meet to examine the new safety procedures outlined in the update to the Medford High School Student Handbook (as sent to families on January 2, 2023) from a D.E.I. perspective.

2023-02 As offered by Sharon Hays, Resolution for New Safety and Discipline Procedures at Medford High School:

Whereas the Medford Public Schools is committed to understanding and supporting the academic, social, emotional, and physical needs of our diverse student population;

Be it resolved, that the subcommittee on Diversity, Equity and Inclusion will meet to review the new safety and discipline procedures at Medford High School. Data relevant to the implementation of the new procedures will also be reviewed.

Chair/Member McLaughlin opens the meeting and takes Roll Call:

Subcommittee Members: all present: 3/0
Chair/Member McLaughlin, Member Hays, Member Ruseau

Public Participation: Paul D'Alleva, Paul Gerety, Lisa Evangelista, Jess (?)

Chair/Member McLaughlin asks Principal D'Alleva to provide some background in terms of changes to the student handbook.

Principal D'Alleva speaks - not too many changes occurred more than things being focused on regarding the handbook and reminding students of some rules that had lapsed a little. No specific changes to speak of; those usually go through the site council, who presents the handbook from there. Mentions the 10-Point action plan that reflected pieces from within the handbook that were currently stated already.

Member Hays asks about the original resolutions that she wrote that led to this meeting and voted on back in February. She comments it wasn't really so much about the Student Handbook - the original resolution was more open ended and came about after the new safety procedures were put in place. She had sent some questions to administration via email and thought it was something the DEI Subcommittee should convene and speak about the new safety procedures - how that impacts the student experience at school - how we think about some of our specific subgroups - how having another resource officer - how having an increased number of hallway and bathroom monitors can have an impact on our students of color; thinking about the bathroom closures and restrictions - and how that impacts students with disabilities and students with anxiety about using the bathroom and some of the LGBTQ students who might need a gender neutral bathroom. She is looking more for an open ended kind of brainstorming session and are there things that the school committee might want to either get more info on from the Administration. Might there be data that the school committee would like to request. Do we want to ask for a report about this - are there any policies we might want to think about, that would be related to when there are changes like this for students and how to address the possible unintended consequences of new procedures from the student perspective, particularly marginalized students and how it might impact their experience.

Principal D'Alleva speaks and addresses the bathrooms. What has been more noticeable is, with the limits (imposed) on how many students that are allowed in a bathroom - we are seeing lines of students outside the bathroom. These lines would not have been seen before. Between classes, the bathrooms are closed and there's a monitor in place. When the bathrooms are reopened, there are more students observed out of class. There is a procedure of having to get the pass in order to access the bathroom, which can delay getting back to class. No matter how many bathrooms are open, there are still lines to use the bathroom. Individual bathrooms are available such as the gender neutral (single stall) bathroom in the main office. We want to have as many bathrooms open as possible. Downstairs by the theater is another gender neutral bathroom. The student has to get the key from the security guard to use the bathroom. From a DEI perspective, you don't want students missing class; however, you don't want students being uncomfortable and trying to figure out when to use the bathroom.

Principal D'Alleva continues and speaks to the monitoring; when they (the administration) tried to keep the bathrooms open, teachers were losing prep in order to do this. With teachers out, there was the need to shuffle and scramble to figure out who's what where. For instance, if classes need to be covered, that takes priority over the bathroom monitoring and that occurs as well.

Member McLaughlin speaks .. she would be curious if there would be any data collection on any student increase and behavior referrals or request to leave classrooms based on any subgroups and these new procedures that could be helpful.

Member Hays asks the same question about data and the points that Principal D'Alleva spoke about with the bathroom and curious about a way to keep data in terms of how class time students are missing - do we have any input from students about missing class. She mentions that at one of the (Regular SC) meetings, one of the student representatives spoke about having a challenge about getting to an open bathroom. They would be interested in how that's working out and as a group, brainstorm ways to figure out if this is a problem and what can be done to alleviate some of those problems; recognises that new procedures are a work in progress.

Principal D'Alleva responds that one thing that has been implemented this year is the e-Hall pass system. If it is being utilized correctly in each class. When a student is requesting a pass, it indicates a timer. They know where a student is going and the time it takes for them to get back. This comes with some challenges that he has seen. For example, when a teacher teaching a class, allows a student to leave, they initiate the start button and then if the student comes back in the middle of instruction, and the teacher forgets to end the pass, if a 30 minute period of time passes, the hall pass shuts down. The teacher has to be constantly watching the timer. If the student has been gone 10 mins, the pass goes to yellow. They (administration) can get the history reports of who is out. There would have to be some cross referencing if you're talking about the type of student. He is able to have access to the whole school that is utilizing e-Hall pass, so there has to be some cross referencing available regarding who's got so many passes versus whatever subgroup you're trying to identify.

Member Hays speaks and asks if the administration is collecting data on impacts of both intended and unintended of the new procedures on students in general. As some of the subgroups are spoken of, originally one of her main concerns when writing the resolution was thinking about the increased adult monitors who are monitoring where students are going and what they're doing. That could have an impact on students of color. She questions if there are differences in who's being spoken to more often or getting referrals and beyond that, has there been any discussion with those students to determine if that is affecting them from a mental health perspective. Do they feel uncomfortable; there is data everywhere that shows this could be an issue.

Principal D'Alleva responds that we (the administration) deals with things on a case by case basis. There are things that come up to his level; there are things that stay at the Assistant Principal level because they work with the families as well as the students. He tends to take a look at the dashboard on schoolbrains - pie chart of the whole school. He agrees that sometimes teasing out subgroups is time consuming but doable. He would like to look at class cuts that was something that was huge but has been diminishing in the past 3 years. He references Mr. Welch's report. That is something that repeatedly comes up time and

time again as a referral basis of figuring it out. Now they are looking at the number of reductions of class cuts that are occurring throughout the year. No matter what, that is the number gamut if he were to run any report. The hard part for him is what he's identifying more with (regard to) the 9th graders, it seems like the upperclassmen are towing the line, but the 9th graders are still trying to figure out how to navigate through the building. They are looking at data; he meets once a week with the assistant principals to go through the data and try to hit some things he has been dealing with and look for solutions to navigate (the issues).

Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent speaks and shares - based on the question that was being asked about the specific data related, are the student demographics being monitored. As they (the team) were looking to stabilize the High School and looking at the behaviors that were occurring, if there happened to be students of color cutting classes, the focus was to get students back into the classroom to ensure the building was safe and everyone was safe and in a secure space. We do look at the work through DEI but they also look at how the high school was functioning and making sure that students were where they needed to be. Yes, that can be looked at but keep in mind, we do want students to be inside their classrooms and not in the hallways. She has spoken to students and escorted them back to class and they weren't doing anything; they were talking and laughing and their teacher was waiting for them and grateful to have them brought back to the classroom.

Member Hays wants to be clear the resolution was not to question the critical need in the moment of that time, for something to change as there were some pretty major issues at the high school. The question is not necessarily about the intended consequences, which was to have students in class and help students feel safe at school. This is not the question of this particular subcommittee meeting or the resolution she put forward. How do we assess and evaluate now we're several months out? What's the impact on students and are there any unintended impacts regarding some of the questions regarding the intended consequences such as students being spoken to more often in the hallways now there are more monitors? Are some students feeling less comfortable in the building if there are more adults overseeing them? Are there students who might find it difficult to access bathrooms now they're close and that might make them anxious or uncomfortable. She is thinking about students with disabilities and anxieties about finding a bathroom LGBTQ students who might have a hard time getting to the main office to use the bathroom could be difficult. How are we giving students a voice to let us (the committee) know and are we looking at data or do we need to look at getting more data to better understand now that we're past the emergency stage, how do we move on and start looking at the other potential impacts of these new procedures. If they are going to be continued next year, we might need to have a better sense of how they're working for the students in terms of how they're feeling about being in school.

Principal D'Alleva speaks to the listening sessions that were held and they continue to do monthly check-ins with certain groups. There's a balance of people that want to have a voice and an imbalance of people that won't or can't speak up for themselves. When he sees people in the listening sessions, he's not seeing the peers that wouldn't speak up or think things aren't status quo and not say how they're really feeling. He questions how to get those students to ... (engage)? There is a certain population in the school who are very articulate, can voice lots of concerns and speak for others - part of our student government. There is also a population that can't speak up for themselves and how do we get them into the forefront. He'd like to get ideas that you (the committee) might have that he doesn't.

Member Hays responds that she is hoping all can brainstorm together. Now that the student survey has been given, hopefully that will provide some data. She is not sure what the questions were, whether they'll be conducive to getting this kind of information. She asks if there are more informal surveys that can be done. She is hoping that others (committee members) have other ideas as to how to get more information from the students and allow them more of an opportunity to speak. She thinks the listening sessions are a great new addition and hopes they will get more formalized and perhaps smaller in size. There are certainly students who won't feel comfortable speaking up and how do we make sure we get all of those students and make sure that they all have an opportunity to let us know who/what the impact is on them.

Principal D'Alleva mentions there is another survey that occurs during MCAS; it is done every year. After session #2, the students take a questionnaire that the state puts out and we (the administration) has that data as well to coincide with the other data we have. He likes that data - called vocal data. He's not sure

what the acronym stands for but it's in the dropbox and we can download and identify certain factors and compare it to what we do with MCAS such as what the district said, what does the state say? He also thinks it is important to look and good to know what's occurring in other communities. He does what is called a 'dart', which takes Medford high school and compares it to the same demographics. He looks at that data in general, like enrollment and it compares it to a school that's similar in demographics. If he can see that, he can look at the vocal data and drill down on that other school to figure out what they are seeing in their school that is different. He is in constant contact with the Malden high school principal too. Malden is a more diverse community than Medford is; they share observations with regard to subgroups and student/teacher interactions. There is other data out there too. Hopefully when we get the survey we (the administration) can cross-reference it with the vocal data, when it comes out.

Member McLaughlin comments that data collection sounds like a good idea in terms of ensuring the equity piece and she would be curious as to Member Hays reflection on data collection and asks if you (Member Hays?) would want to reconvene to consider that.

Member Hays is unclear as to what Member McLaughlin is proposing; queries that we (subcommittee) convene to consider what kinds of data they would like to have or

Member McLaughlin interjects and says no, what the data is saying ... using more data to If the performance is to use data to see how this is affecting the students, both with the student survey and is currently out in this informal recording that Mr D'Alleva was talking about MCAS and others. She asks if it is a discussion to have to reconvene around data. She thinks it is a little tricky to have this discussion in an ambiguous way without knowing exactly what it is we're dealing with or looking for. Yes, we want to look at this information and consider all the ways these new procedures could impact underrepresented populations. So what is the way in which to do that and how would it be reviewed once that occurs.

Member Hays makes a comment that she was hoping that would be part of the brainstorming session with all in the subcommittee, and to talk about it. Everyone has had different experiences, and jobs or parts of our lives we've experienced different ways to gather data. She is trying to figure out how we can get we now have the student survey coming through and how can we do that on a more regular basis, whatever regular time frame we (sub committee) would want it to be. Also getting teachers and families and all those voices who are experiencing the impact of these new safety procedures and understanding from their perspective, what it looks like during the day for them (?) and both the positives and the negatives that would allow us (committee) to better understand what is and what is not working well. We needed some new safety procedures but the reflection piece is something we haven't really addressed for those who are actually living with them. Originally, this was written back in February. It is still an open question as to how we continue to get this kind of information.

Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent speaks and is in support of that (?). She shares that she just came from a listening session at the Missisquoi. Especially at the high school and as the year is winding down, with freshman semi-formal and senior prom coming up; graduation in the first week of June ... it would be a great opportunity to reach out to high school staff to offer some additional listening sessions to get feedback from the teachers about what strategies and structures were implemented this year, had a positive impact, made a difference and a change. We could gather that information; we have a little bit of time when the school year ends at the high school level, we have a few half days for students and we can try to work creatively with some of that time, which is also used for planning for the summer and for the new coursework. We can work to get the data with Mr D'Alleva and Mr Fallon to gather informal feedback and look into the possibility of conducting surveys. She does feel more information is captured from in-person and face-to face personal conversations with people. This can be an action item to meet and talk with the staff about this. As we get ready for a new year, we'll be able to start the new year strong. We have learned a lot but (need) to continue to build upon that learning. It is possible that she will communicate with the staff and share that we (the administration) want to hear from them as we plan to learn from their experiences.

Member Hays agrees the listening sessions are a valuable too. She would ask if there is a way to have for some people, having a face-to-face is more difficult. So having both - maybe a written or a more

anonymous or less 'confrontational' (she states, not the right word) way for people who might feel more comfortable doing it in a different way - to get as much information as we can as we move forward.

Principal D'Alleva speaks and notes with data, it is always interesting because you can tell a story in so many different ways. One of the key points is to see all the data and then we tease out what we're looking for. That's (data) something that gets lost in translation as well. This has been a point of discussion a lot thanks to his (?). He has been trying to digress on an academic level. Trying to identify students that need more support. Not just MCAS, but MAP. Then it all comes together and he builds a profile to find supports for a student in need. All these data points are pointing into (this?) certain direction. One of the other tools he uses in analytics is called Early Warning. It looks at MCAS scores, student attendance, etc throughout the year before they even get to high school, which helps him identify those students as well and start them off in the Nexus program, look at all the data points first; then assess and review all the data moving forward.

Member Hays speaks about what the motion should be. She mentions the student survey and doesn't know how long it takes to get the data and to work with the interpretation of that. Then if something could be done with the teachers' listening sessions or something else, would we want to come back to this committee with some of that information to talk about it before taking it to the full committee? Or do we want to make a motion to bring it to the last committee meeting of the school year? Asks for input.

Member Ruseau thinks there is a report policy (or procedure) and he thinks it would be helpful to ... and it's the rule to follow that. Most importantly is for the committee to write out exactly what it is they want. Otherwise the potential is to have multiple meetings to get to what they want. He thinks the full committee should decide whether to approve the report and the superintendent should have the opportunity to say what length of time, which is the report procedure in the first place.

Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent comments that especially where there are two regular meetings left in the year, and with the current amount of subcommittee meetings we have, plus the budget meetings, from a data perspective, gathering the data from the teachers at the end of the year, giving us time to look at that data when we receive the other student survey data, and to be able to digest and look at all the data, to provide a coherent report by the last meeting of the year, would be rushing critically important data. We can have it, look at it and determine what the data is saying, it would be appropriate to report out to the committee at the start of the school year - or share with the community what we have obtained so far and provide a summary analysis as to what the data says. She doesn't want to report for the sake of reporting and not have the opportunity to digest what the information is saying. Some of this information needs to be shared with the incoming principal for her to think about what her vision is for the school and how the data makes sense in terms of what will happen next year at the school. She doesn't think it would be wise to rush to check the box to say we did it but not able to properly report. Even with the start of the new year, be a little more restrictive at the beginning and then do a gradual release to see what could happen. A lot of thought, strategy and coordination of the team that needs to take place. She is asking the committee to consider (these points).

Member McLaughlan speaks and looks for confirmation from the superintendent to: data collection to reconvene in the Fall around looking at taking the surveys that are currently out, looking at that data and the teacher roundtable - having that data and coming back to either the subcommittee or at the full school committee.

Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent is willing to present at a regular committee meeting as a report - speaking to data collection, conducting listening sessions, doing some kind of survey with the teachers. Looking at the date, letting the school year start and in September, suggests a teacher listening session, asking them for quick feedback before reporting back to the larger committee with the results of the data.

Member McLaughlan asks Member Hays what she thinks of that.

Member Hays confirms it would be great for the start. She mentions she would be for another meeting to talk more about ongoing data collection. If these restrictions or safety procedures continue, she thinks

gathering ongoing data about the impact on teachers and students and thinks it's important that whenever a significant change in the way the school is run, especially for the experience of the students, that data is continued to be looked at and how it's impacting them with intended and unintended consequences to ensure that we keep looking for that because that is our responsibility to do that.

Member McLaughlin comments that it's a good start to have something to build on in September. She is fine having that conversation on the Agenda for the School Committee meeting as a whole. From there it can be discussed as either data response or data information particularly around a regular thing (?) or part of a report as Member Ruseau spoke of. To get all to a starting point, it would be helpful to have this as an Agenda item at the end of September to allow for time to collect data. If the rest of the members are in agreement with that, she will make a motion to adjourn.

Member Hays asks about, (and speaks to Member Ruseau's comments) about writing a formal request for a report? Is it (Agenda item) being left open ended, knowing it (Agenda item) will on and who will be responsible for making sure it goes on the agenda.

Member McLaughlin comments that she thinks that to Member Ruseau's point, if you (Member Hays ?) are looking for a full report, that then would be something that would need to go through the policy. We've already written a report. She would recommend having it be a little more ambiguous in terms of following the superintendent's lead around having her present the data at the school committee meeting. She also thinks you (Member Hays ?) can be more specific with both the superintendent and Mr D'Alleva about some of the data points you are specifically looking for, so that it will be an informed presentation. That's always good practice for what you want for the presentation. From that point, if you feel the committee or other members have the prerogative to ask for additional information, or they think this should be a regular report, you can follow the procedure from there. Her feeling is because this is new and there is some ambiguity around it and people are feeling their way around it. It would be good to start with this first step and see how the data is presented with a clear expectation either from an email or ... about the data. It is a matter of emailing the Superintendent (and her assistant) to get it on to the Agenda in September and she has full confidence that can happen.

Member Hays comments that her question was a little more basic than that. Out of this meeting, do we have a motion that says it will be in the month of September, that we will have a meeting about that - how do we leave it from here to present to the rest of the committee. Again, she is concerned that things get lost over the summer, and she doesn't want ... she wants to have enough of a final outcome.

Member McLaughlin does not think a motion is necessary but that's Member Hays prerogative. We can report out to the whole and she can do that as the chair and give Member Hays the opportunity to speak as well and share with the rest of the school committee; that we had a discussion; we asked for some data points and the superintendent agreed she will provide these data points in September. For the next meeting, we can ask the Superintendent to provide the date. Maybe this makes things a little more comfortable.

Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent speaks and says she was looking at the September calendar and we haven't determined the committee meeting dates yet. September 4 is Labor Day, so September 11 is the first meeting. Because meetings are (held) on the 1st and 3rd (weeks of the month), it's either going to be the 11th and the 18th or the 18th and the 25th. The first Monday in October is the 2nd. Given that school starts on Wednesday, 30th (August?), we would only have two days of school in August, followed by the short week and so she would ask that it (the report) could be at (on the agenda) the October 2nd meeting, which would give us between start school, have a few weeks of data to be able to report out to the committee.

Member McLaughlin says that works for her and she's confident reporting that out. Member Hays, we don't need to have a motion to make that happen. It seems like it's already happened. It's really about the conversation and some of the brainstorming about how we (the committee) are ensuring that this is an equitable ... that we (the committee) are putting into practice, equitable practice for all of our student

population and really considering the impact that significant changes can have on more of our underrepresented population. She will report this out at the next (regular) meeting.

Motion to adjourn the meeting made by Member McLaughlin; seconded by Member Ruseau.

Motion carries: 3/0

Meeting adjourns: 5:53p